19

1923, National College

From Kartar Singh Sarabha in the First Lahore Conspiracy Case in 1915 to the Amritsar Massacre in 1917, and then from Ashfaqullah Khan in the Kakori Conspiracy Case of 1925 to the Babbar Akali Agitation of 1926, Bhagat Singh had been so deeply touched by martyrs and martyrdom that he had written about their sacrifices in endearing terms. But alongside these influences, which left a lasting impression on his young mind from the age of eight in 1915 until the age of nineteen in 1926, there was also the influence on him of the National College, into which he gained admission at the age of fourteen years.

Here there were two further influences that made his transformation complete as a revolutionary freedom fighter. These in particular shaped Bhagat Singh's life in his later years. First, there were the students with whom Bhagat Singh got to rub shoulders. These included names like Sukhdev, Bhagwati Charan Vohra, Yash Pal, Jaidev Gupta and Ram Krishen, all of whom participated in the Lahore Conspiracy Case 1931. Bhagat Singh's association with them remained steadfast, and although he left the National College a year later, he continued to visit it right up to 1926, the year when he was first arrested as a nineteen-year-old by the Lahore Police for being associated with the Kakori case. Second, there were the teachers of the National College in Lahore who left a lasting impression on him. Firebrands such as Acharya Jugal Kishore and Uday Shankar Bhatt were radical, free-thinking and irreverent.

Such teachers were openly contemptuous of the supine weakness of the non-violent non-cooperation satyagraha movement of Mahatma Gandhi, which they believed was singularly ineffective in delivering the kind of